Final Portfolio and Reflection

Henry Shires

Eulogy

As we all have witnessed throughout our years knowing him, our beloved Henry was never far from reach. His kind and wise presence filled up the room every time we gathered as a family. His devoted heart to his wife and children was never shadowed by anything, his light gleaming in all aspects of his life. Even in his career, he never once hesitated to do what was right for his employees and fellow executives, even when temptation said to go another way. His mind was never motivated by riches and fame, only how his impact affected the ones close to him. The way Henry truly loved people was unique in a way and will be missed by all who had the pleasure to meet him.

My communication habits and processes

When beginning a piece, I first brainstorm ideas by comparing the requirements of the piece with subjects I am passionate about (technology, data, architecture, music, etc.). I am better equipped to capture my thoughts and effectively present them on paper by establishing an emotional connection to my piece. I then try to find a specific topic to write about by either speaking aloud or writing down my thoughts. This process results in keywords I can utilize to create a topic sentence or web search for completing my thesis and main idea.

I start drafting by outlining the entire piece, from the introduction and thesis to evidence/body paragraphs, and finally, the conclusion. I add concise bullet points and headings to remember the goal of each section of the piece without wasting time on the details. By planning the foundation of my piece, I can visualize what each section will focus on before I begin writing substance.

As a beginner, my original techniques for drafting consisted of making the first draft extraordinary and as perfect as possible, but this process became time-consuming and wasteful. I quickly learned the term rough draft is accepted for a reason: the first few iterations of a piece should be *rough* or barebones, containing holes and missing parts. The goal is to record initial ideas and perfect them with new iterations of a piece. Now, when I finish a rough draft, I enjoy finding an abundance of places to improve my pieces, such as fixing repeated word choices and phrasing. The thesaurus and Ctrl + F soon became my two best friends during this process.

My communication skills

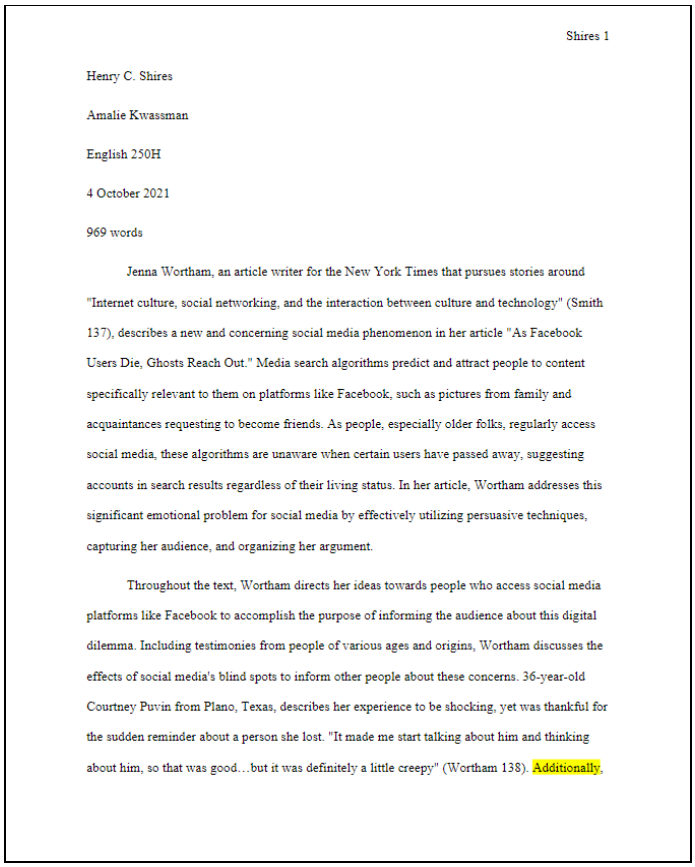
I find myself to have strengths, mostly in writing and electronic communication. I can determine how to phrase a thought correctly and effectively with very little time required in writing. I naturally include transitional phrases, find adequate synonyms for common words (given a thesaurus occasionally), and write bold, passionate sentences that captivate my audience. Although it may take multiple iterations of a draft, I will achieve beyond surface-level substance in my creativity or argument evidence (depending on the piece) and correctly organize my piece to match a common outline of my type of written work. My style also tends to be technical and profound, yet creative and unique, items that tend to match my character.

When it comes to electronic communication, I feel especially strong in this area. I have many years of experience creating digital works from tinkering in my free time and computer classes in high school. To start, I have a website and LinkedIn page to showcase my high school and college projects/resume online. I developed these tools to communicate my skills to employers to land a solid career path. Additionally, this website features a few of my media creations, such as short films and video presentations. I have films on adventures, travel, and even one on explaining the fundamentals of a computer. Therefore, I can confidently say I can create a visually-appealing presentation of any digital medium that captures my audience and effectively delivers information.

Bringing in college credit from multiple English classes in high school, I've felt well prepared to enter language arts at Iowa State. However, I have also noticed areas where I continue to improve as a communicator. I continue to understand the importance of seeking feedback from my peers, as multiple pairs of eyes reviewing an idea leads to better results, accuracy, and clarity. I also need further practice with oral communication, as my ideas are sometimes unclear or fragmented when I present them. By working harder to prepare a presentation or written work, I can improve my ability to effectively communicate ideas in my work and find new things to learn.

Written communication skills

My written communication skills are most exemplified through my rhetorical analysis. The assignment required the creation of an argument about a text's use of rhetorical strategies and why or why not it effectively implemented these strategies. I chose to analyze a New York Times article by journalist Jenna Wortham about the persistence of accounts on social media belonging to users who have died. For the thesis of my analysis, I claimed, "Wortham addresses this significant emotional problem for social media by effectively utilizing persuasive techniques, capturing her audience, and organizing her argument."



Shires 1

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English 250H

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969 words

Jenna Wortham, an article writer for the New York Times that pursues stories around "Internet culture, social networking, and the interaction between culture and technology" (Smith 137), describes a new and concerning social media phenomenon in her article "As Facebook Users Die, Ghosts Reach Out." Media search algorithms predict and attract people to content specifically relevant to them on platforms like Facebook, such as pictures from family and acquaintances requesting to become friends. As people, especially older folks, regularly access social media, these algorithms are unaware when certain users have passed away, suggesting accounts in search results regardless of their living status. In her article, Wortham addresses this significant emotional problem for social media by effectively utilizing persuasive techniques, capturing her audience, and organizing her argument.

Throughout the text, Wortham directs her ideas towards people who access social media platforms like Facebook to accomplish the purpose of informing the audience about this digital dilemma. Including testimonies from people of various ages and origins, Wortham discusses the effects of social media's blind spots to inform other people about these concerns. 36-year-old Courtney Puvin from Plano, Texas, describes her experience to be shocking, yet was thankful for the sudden reminder about a person she lost. "It made me start talking about him and thinking about him, so that was good…but it was definitely a little creepy" (Wortham 138). Additionally,

While we did multiple written works in class, I felt this piece accurately displayed where my skills stood out the most. I felt my submission for this assignment showed the most growth and understanding than the other essays I wrote for this class. My language choices, organization, development, information, and argument all seem exceptional in this piece, exemplifying the practice I've had from many high school English courses as well as the lessons I've learned from this class. Since the article I analyzed relates to social media, a modern pastime, I phrased my language to appeal to social media users since they are the group of people to most likely find interest in this article. I then make strong and clear claims to boldly announce to the audience what I want them to agree with. Peer review largely benefited this piece as it prevented hidden fallacies, fragments, and unclarities when looked at with a fresh pair of eyes.

In the quote below, I sufficiently conclude my essay with each of the main takeaways from my analysis. I re-state my thesis, but this time making sure to include connected and valued background information for the reader to connect the dots and form a mental model of the argument. My word choice is strong and non-passive to sound clear and professional so I can effectively persuade the reader

into an agreement. Since the conclusion is the audience's last impression of my work, it needs to make the most sense and summarize what I want the reader to remember the most:

"To capture a relevant audience, Wortham creates a phenomenal argument to accomplish her purpose of informing the public about addressing the reality of death and its relation to digital networks. She utilizes argument development such as pathos, ethos, and logos to strengthen her argument with emotional connection, logic, and credibility. Finally, she wisely organizes her argument and reasoning to inform her audience of the seemingly subtle flaw in social networks that may unintentionally harm, and in rare cases delight, many lives."

When writing for this class, I repeatedly learned it's important to pace the writing process across multiple days rather than cramming it into only a few days. This pacing allows the process to create deep thoughts that effectively communicate arguments and evidence. Spreading the work also saves worry about deadlines, increases efficiency, and allows for extra time to thoroughly learn the background information and argument sources. The more I know about the argument and subject, the better the piece will turn out. These lessons aided my success in this class and future classes to come, as essays were a large portion of the semester, connecting pieces like this analysis to nearly every English class offered in high school and college.

Oral, visual, and electronic communication skills



My oral, visual, and electronic communication skills are most exemplified through my multimodal design. The assignment required creating a multimodal piece that utilizes deliberate design and rhetorical choices to make an effective argument on the subject of death. I chose to produce a short film presenting the severity of the terrorist attacks of 9/11. My film gave a snapshot of the visual horror from that day in history to an audience born after 9/11 or too young to remember the day. I seized the common phrase “a picture is worth a thousand words” when making this film, as the scenes are nearly all pictures and few words to emphasize the visual argument the scenes portray. The tragedy and horror of the event pierce through the darker colors, somber soundtrack, and jarring statistics.

I selected this piece as my best work due to its uniqueness from my other works during the semester. No other students in my section presented a film for this assignment, and nearly everyone made simple slideshows (including me) to present their work at some point in the semester. Therefore, I felt this piece was the best unique representation of my electronic work that encapsulated oral and visual communication. I instantly drew in my audience with a black screen, a slow fade-in of the soundtrack, and a disturbing image of the New York skyline with the Twin Towers in flames. These subtleties created a dramatic hook to capture my audience.

Next, as I introduced important points, I kept the text concise and transitioned to more photos. These actions kept the visuals fresh so the audience would stay engaged. For example, “Never Forget” connects the audience with a phrase relevant to the 9/11 tragedy but also continues audience engagement to the very end as the concise phrase still



carries a dramatic and dutiful message: to never take this country for granted and make it known that America never throws in the towel. The dark background contrasts the white text for enhanced effect.

After I completed my work, and since there was no official peer review for this assignment, I took it upon myself to show my friends my final product. While they were ill-informed on the assignment criteria, I could instantly get insight on where and when improvements were needed or not needed based on their facial expressions and informal feedback. None of them were nervous about being honest, and everyone respected me as they gave feedback. This assignment connected with other work I did for this class, as I observed the communication style differed greatly from a written essay. The process for developing a piece remained equal (brainstorming, outlining, writing/filming/gathering information, revising, peer review).

“Thank you for your hard work, thank you for making the nation proud, and may God bless America!” - President George W. Bush.

As I’ve had experience making films before, I executed many of the same techniques I’m familiar with in writing, developing, and editing. The challenging part involved finding images, clips, and audio that I had permission to obtain and making sure I properly cited them all. I ended up with quite a handful of media sources, so I quickly learned I needed to record each source as I found one rather than searching back for all of them at the end. In all of my films, I limit myself to the maximum duration of my soundtrack to get my points communicated. This length limit challenges me to effectively communicate my argument while remaining concise. Overall I enjoyed making my creative vision come to life on screen and challenging myself to apply alternate argument techniques rather than writing another essay. The entire film can be viewed here:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8bEtY1ExLwo

Final Reflection

Dear Mrs. K,

My vision for my future is quite broad, as I will appreciate any big or small accomplishments I make as I go. However, I want to positively impact our modern world using my passion for technology. Technology has shaped and continues to innovate many industries. I dream of leading this innovation movement, in big ways or small, in some capacity.

I am passionate about information technology, organization, productivity, entrepreneurship, and music. I listen to music for, on average, ~3.5 hours a day. In particular, listening and playing (drums) is a core part of my daily routine. I am constantly striving to get things done so I can feel gratified. Doing meaningful work helps me feel valued and possess a purpose. I am naturally a planner and critical thinker. I can easily visualize a problem, find a solution, and plan my action steps. I am very aware of my surroundings and can recall very specific things. I am also self-motivated about almost everything, so deadlines and quality of work are rarely a problem for me. These qualities set me up for success in my field, so accomplishing my goals will be aided significantly. My well-rounded interests in STEM and music allow me to think creatively and practically at the same time which may lead to alternative and better solutions to problems.

I hope to be a software or hardware engineer with a team, with an office space of warm colors, open-concept, and full of resources. The open environment with colors and spaces to collaborate allows for productivity between teams for maximum efficiency. The warm and welcoming environment allows for positive morale, so everyone feels motivated and encouraged. The vibe of the city and the welcoming space to collaborate will make me feel valued as I work. Given these aspects of my vision, I identify with being a future Elon Musk as I have very similar passions for bettering the world with technology. While Musk's work seems extremely large scale, I would be ok with small or large accomplishments. More importantly, his forward-thinking and drive to make the world a better and more advanced place is what most inspires me.

In order to accomplish these goals, I need to effectively communicate my ideas and my progress to teammates and supervisors. I may need to argue a project idea or solution via a proposal in written form. In visual form, I may need to present research, a product overview, or other forms of information about my work. In oral form, I may need to argue or speak about solutions I come up with to persuade my superiors my idea is worth pouring resources into. Finally, in electronic form, I may need to document my

processes, solutions, research, and other digital artifacts for colleagues to review or utilize in their work.

I am proficient in these skills, partially due to this class and its curriculum to practice these effective communication skills. I can further build upon my growth by practicing independently with projects I complete for other projects. I can recall processes or important concepts (in-text citations, organization, development, etc.) when creating a communication piece, so my argument becomes stronger than if I hadn't taken 250H at all. Finally, to verify I reach improvement every new project, I can continue to utilize peer review. By asking my friend to quickly review something, I already have instant feedback I can implement to perfect my work, even if the review consists of only a few glances from someone.

Before this class, I didn't consider much about the concept of death. It has always been in the back of my mind, but I hadn't given it much thought. Much less did I expect my freshman English class would discuss the seriousness and broad range of ideas about death. However, after taking it, I have enjoyed the many new things I refreshed myself on or heard about for the first time. In articles from *Death* by Rachelle M. Smith, such as "Curtains: Adventures of an Undertaker-in-Training," I learned about the intricacies of embalming corpses for funerals and burial ceremonies through the light humor of the author's first-person creative writing approach. I increased my exposure to scientific evidence around Near-Death Experiences (NDEs), which are most likely related to recently discovered brain functions. Finally, I enjoyed writing our eulogies to understand American death culture compared to the ideas and customs about other countries discussed in class.

To achieve this vision for the future, I have outlined these goals below:

- Goal 1: I will finish a previously-started minimally viable product for my software company, Casmium, LLC, by the end of this year, 2021.
    - Action: I will input a minimum of 5 hours a week into complete items on the company tasklist
    - Action: I will seek help, support, or resources from the internet, my teammates, and potential clients about items that need work completed, item criteria, and when these items need to be completed.
    - Milestone: I will know that what I'm doing is working when our product completes one robust test run from start to end with a 100% success rate.
- Goal 2: I will obtain a Bachelor's Degree in Computer Engineering with Honors by May 2025.
    - Action: I will complete all required work on time and with my best effort.

- Action: I will treat each weekday as a 9-to-5 occupation so that I am studying as maximally as possible and am using my time as efficiently as possible for the sake of my health and well-being.
- Action: I will take breaks and involve myself in creative or less-academic activities to balance my load of thinking (marching band, clubs, rec).
- Action: I will take into consideration not only my physical health but my mental, emotional, and spiritual health each day.
- Milestone: I will know that what I'm doing is working when I maintain a 3.5 GPA or higher each semester during my four years.

My experiences in 250H have allowed me to improve not only as a communicator but as a learner. I've had to balance multiple assignments testing different skills, think critically and creatively to produce unique language arts pieces, work in groups, and effectively communicate ideas from texts and arguments. I felt challenged the most with exemplifying my skills through all four areas of communication. This type of challenge seemed comfortable to me, allowing for positive growth in my abilities to write, analyze, present, and create. Overall this class solidified a core component of becoming a leader in the industry: presenting information and arguing this information in a way that "sticks" (the argument appeals to the audience, and the work is professional). In addition, thank you for being a great facilitator of my learning and equipping me with a semester of invaluable skill-building.

Sincerely,
Henry Shires